

CHENNAI • Thursday, March 19, 2026



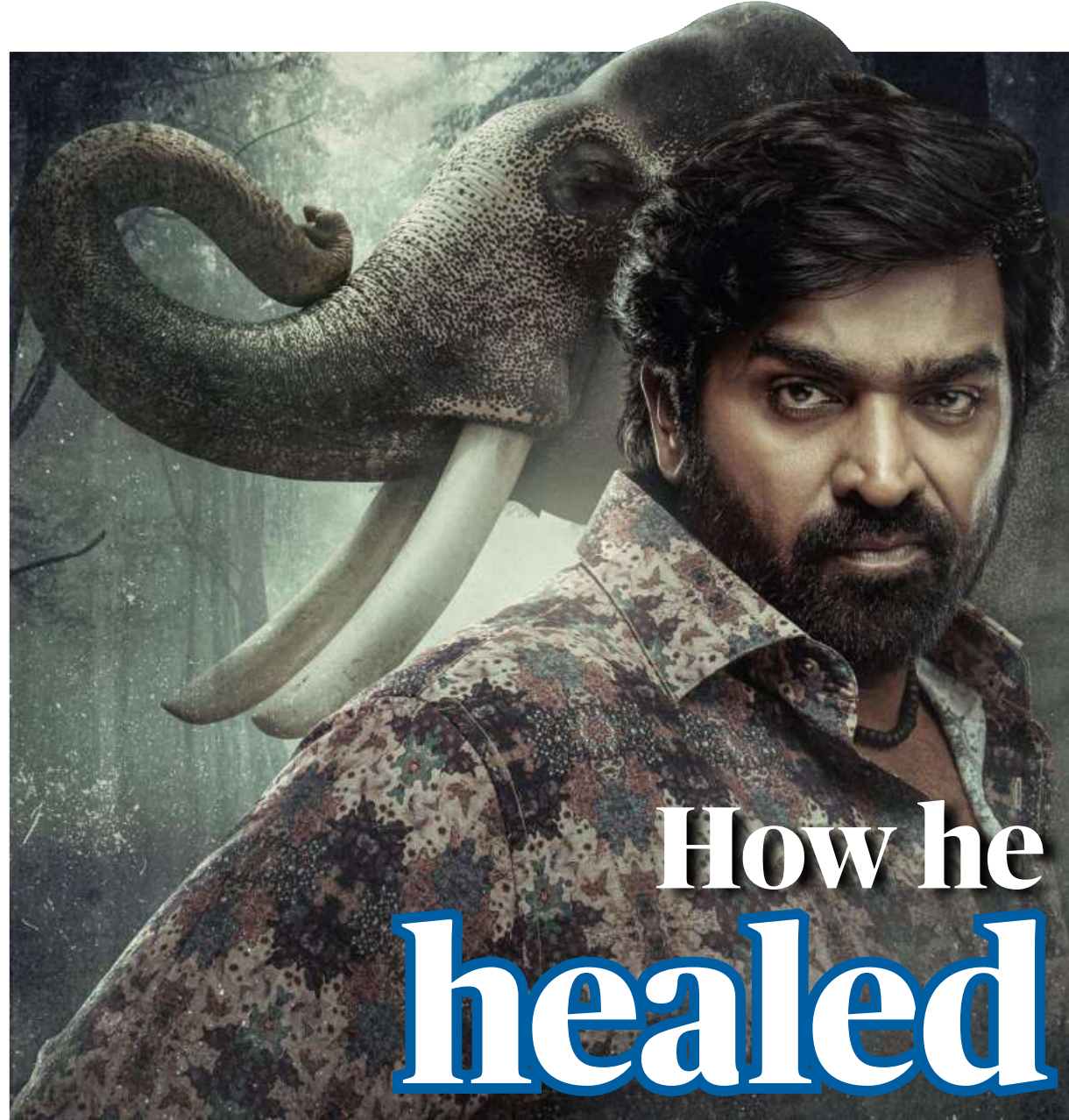
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THE HINDU



An Iranian's poignant love letter to her country in the form of chello kebabs in Chennai **P3**

RAJISHA VIJAYAN'S STRIKING NEW TURN **P4**



How he healed

Actor Vijay Sethupathi on a long, dramatic, and consistently evolving relationship with the world of cinema, and his latest *Muthu Engira Kaattaan*

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When I meet Vijay Sethupathi at Prasad Studios in Chennai, he is wrapping up a day of filming for Thiagarajan Kumararaja's *Pocket Novel*. It is 6pm and the actor has not had lunch yet. His team is milling around, helping him get out of make up. In his caravan, I notice a set of weights, a keyboard, and a stack of neatly arranged books. This is the actor in his natural habitat. This is a performer who has averaged at least four releases a year for over a decade.

He will be making his Tamil web-series debut later this month with *Muthu Engira Kaattaan* on JioHotstar, reuniting with friend and collaborator M Manikandan, who previously directed him in *Aandavan Kattalai* and *Kadaisi Vivasayi*. Manikandan is the creator of the series, and shares direction credits with B Ajith Kumar.

"This story, sort of, healed me," Sethupathi says. He harkens back to a time when he felt stuck after the pandemic, and brings up something he learnt through distance healing.

"I was told then that we are not clouds, but the sky. Clouds are something that simply come and go in our lives. When I read the script of *Kaattaan*, I felt like the clouds in my life cleared and I was able to see the sky. It cleansed me," he reflects.

A noir-folk thriller, the web series unfolds in a sleepy village whose inhabitants are rattled when a severed human head is discovered. The story follows two policemen attempting to unravel the identity behind it. The first two episodes, a fantastic coming together of dark comedy, absurd humour, and a police procedural, keep viewers

An actor prepares Vijay Sethupathi in the web series *Muthu Engira Kaattaan*, a noir-folk thriller. JIOHOTSTAR



guessing; who really is Muthu?

"I do not set out to do something with the mindset that it is going to be 'amazing'. It feels egoistic to me," says the actor, when asked if he feels any pressure to deliver something path-breaking. "This is not what someone should be thinking of, especially while pursuing art. I am just doing my job, and what is important is to do it wholeheartedly," he says while acknowledging the comfort of working with frequent collaborators like, Manikandan or Thiagarajan Kumararaja, with whom he worked earlier in *Super Deluxe* (2019).

"There is freedom... I can talk openly, have discussions, and I know I will not be judged," he adds.

Beginning his acting career with Chennai-based theatre group, Koothu-p-Pattarai, Vijay Sethupathi went on to star in several short films, a Tamil TV serial, and played supporting roles in movies before his big break as the lead in Karthik Subbaraj's *Pizza*. A 2020 profile of his in *The Hindu* dubbed him the face of a new wave in Tamil cinema, where his constant desire for re-invention helped set him apart from his peers. He has played the protagonist, the antagonist, dabbled in genres across the spectrum, and was also last seen in the silent film *Gandhi Talk*.

CONTINUED ON
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How he healed

CONTINUED FROM
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“Short films, TV shows, films or even web series – the format can be anything, but the audience should not be bored. They should find it fascinating. A project, irrespective of the format, has to excite me as well. Acting is the only job I know, and there really is no formula I follow to be different or anything else,” he says.

For him, a day on the set is like a puzzle. “When you walk in, you know what the scene is, but you don’t know how you are going to do it. When we unlock this puzzle, there is a sense of comfort, an achievement of sorts. It feels like finally being able to make an angry girlfriend laugh, after trying hard to impress her,” he laughs.

During the conversation, I bring up how his filmography features a touch of romance and slice-of-life, particularly in *Aandavan Kattalai* (2016) and *Kaadhalum Kadandhu Pogum* (2016). “Do you know today marks 10 years since *Kaadhalum Kadandhu Pogum* was released?” he asks. We discuss the film, and how it continues to be celebrated among cinephiles, for how it tackles companionship, camaraderie, and the underlying romance of it all. *Aandavan Kattalai* too, he points out, had a sweet, subtle romance that slowly comes

together in the end, something that he loved about the film.

“I have done so many love stories, and however many I do, or everyone does...*theeradhadhu andha kaadhal dhaan* (Love is seemingly endless),” he says, waxing lyrical about his love for the genre. He points out the variety of love stories in his filmography, right from *Soodhu Kavvum* (2013), where he falls in love with a woman from his imagination, and *Idharkuthane Aasaipattai Balakumara* (2013), where he is head over heels for his neighbour, to the hard-hitting *Ka Pae Ranasingham* (2020), about a wife struggling to bring back her husband’s body from abroad, the absurd comedy *Naanum Rowdy Dhaan* (2015), and the smash-hit *96* (2018).

As the pan-Indian cinema frenzy continues in the country, Sethupathi is no stranger to it as well, having starred in the blockbuster film *Jawan* (2023) alongside Shah Rukh Khan. “The progression to making pan-Indian films feels natural, and it is something that I welcome. Of course, there will be some complaints, but isn’t it a good thing when a film becomes a film for everyone, and gets celebrated by all?” he asks. “To me, it feels like a cultural exchange,” he states.

The actor brings up the example of his own film *Maharaja* (2024), one that enjoyed commercial success



(Clockwise from far left) Vijay Sethupathi in *Maharaja*; 96; *Vikram*; *Muthu Engira Kaattaan*; and *Super Deluxe*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND JIOHOTSTAR



across the country, and also broke records in China. “We might think people see a film only for the story, but there is so much more they must have observed, Our homes, food, relationships, economic status, transport, education... it isn’t just a story that transcends borders, but the film also serves as a documentation of life and culture of the era we are in,” he explains.

Beyond entertainment He recalls something that filmmaker SP Jananathan, who directed him in *Purampokku Engira Podhuvudamai* (2015) and *Laabam* (2021), believed in. “He always said cinema isn’t just entertainment; it educates us in many ways. I believe that too. It’s not just about claps and whistles, it depends on what you take away from a film. If one crore people watch it, at least 10 will carry something from it in the form of a lyric that moved them, or the spark to become a doctor, a scientist, or even joining the Army. A two-and-a-half-hour film can plant many such seeds,” he says.

The progression to making pan-Indian films feels natural, and it is something that I welcome. Isn’t it a good thing when a film becomes a film for everyone, and gets celebrated by all?



importantly, there are other actors who have played smaller roles,” he says.

Having played several supporting roles in films before his big break as a lead actor, he dwells on this. “For actors who have done small roles, starring in a film that does well becomes a marker of sorts. It creates an identity. We can write the name of these films behind the photos we hand out. And we can move forward for better roles,” the actor adds. “It is good for everyone when a film does well. Everyone benefitting will pay tax as well and it is good for the Government too,” he chuckles.

While *Muthu Engira Kaattaan* is set to release on March 27, Sethupathi has a slew of films coming up as well. “I look forward to everything I am working on. Why will I work on projects that do not excite me?” he asks. “Puri Jagannadh’s *Slum Dog- 33 Temple Road* is a script which has piqued my interest. I am also doing Balaji Tharaneedharan’s next, Mani (Ratnam) sir’s next, as well as the second season of *Farzi*, and of course, *Pocket Novel*,” he says, adding, “It is due to my stories and my directors that my work blossoms beautifully. If I am not excited, I simply cannot work.”

Muthu Engira Kaattaan will be available to stream on JioHotstar from March 27.
For a related interview, See page 4

Feast from the desert

Cookbook *Relishing Rajasthan* was launched with performances, a live demo, and a four-course meal inspired by it



A royal affair Author Pratibha Jain and Chef Sameer Gupta at the launch of *Relishing Rajasthan*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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The Duchess Club at the Savera Hotel was filled with the aroma of fennel, chilli, and caramelised sugar, for the launch of Rajasthanian cookbook *Relishing Rajasthan* by Pratibha Jain and Chef Sameer Gupta. The launch, hosted by members of the Duchess Club, was an afternoon of performance, conversation, and a meal inspired by the book.

Pratibha Jain admitted that *Relishing Rajasthan* published by Westland Books, was, in many ways, long overdue. Growing up with the cuisine, she said, had made it feel ordinary; something so familiar it barely registered as special. “For me, Rajasthanian food was comfort food. I never really paid attention to it, and never saw how special it was. I was more excited exploring other cuisines because they felt new. It was only when I started working on this book, and spent time with Sameer ji, that I realised how little I actually knew. It felt like rediscovering home,” said Pratibha.

Chef Sameer, who is not a native of the region, learnt about the cuisine from home kitchens rather than

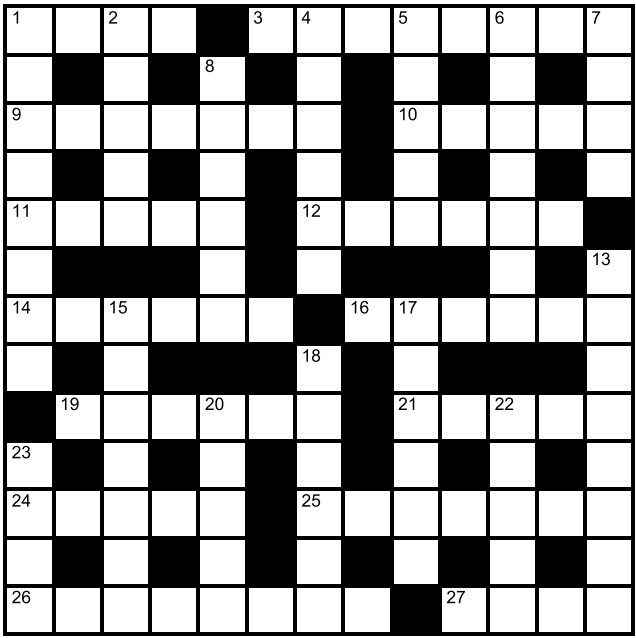
professional ones. The foundation of the book, he emphasised, lay in everyday ingenuity of how simple pantry staples like papad, badi, or even leftover bhujia could be transformed into something inventive. The intent was not to reinvent the cuisine, but to extend it while keeping its character intact.

The book draws deeply from Rajasthan’s vegetarian traditions, particularly the Oswali Jain cuisine of Shekhawati, shaped by community knowledge, home kitchens, and Chef Sameer’s travels across regions and tribal food cultures. Chef walked the audience through a demo to make bhujia pakoda, and angoor ki launji that balanced sweet and sharp.

The sit-down lunch, was a four-course affair. The meal opened with small bites of jhol ki pakodi and tanatan kofta, before moving into a generous dal baati churma course, followed by Bikaneri, dhokla and a Mewadi couse. By the time lunch wound down, the book had already done its job of moving from page to plate, and into conversation.

Relishing Rajasthan: Time-honoured Vegetarian Recipes from a Chef’s Home Kitchen is available online.

QUICK CROSSWORD #45 (Set by Doppelganger)



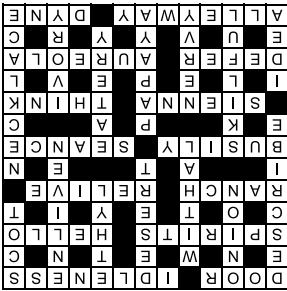
- Across**
- 1 Means of access (4)
 - 3 Inactivity (8)
 - 9 Supernatural beings (7)
 - 10 Greeting (5)
 - 11 Farm in USA (5)
 - 12 Experience again (6)
 - 14 Industiously (6)
 - 16 Meeting (6)
 - 19 Clay pigment (6)
 - 21 Ponder (5)
 - 24 Put off (5)
 - 25 Corona (7)
 - 26 Narrow passage (8)
 - 27 Unit of force (4)
- Down**
- 1 Represent pictorially (8)
 - 2 Bulbous vegetable (5)
 - 4 Abandon (6)
 - 5 Organic compound (5)
 - 6 Animate (7)
 - 7 Member of Gaelic tribe (4)
 - 8 In addition (6)
 - 13 Ornament (8)

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- 15 Adept (7)
- 17 Brasserie (6)
- 18 Edible fruit (6)
- 20 Brazen (5)
- 22 Dentine (5)
- 23 Thought (4)

Solution No. 45



S Poorvaja

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Amidst murals in green and yellow of lush leaves and foliage spilling across the walls of The Botanical Club, new accents of teal, red, and lavender punctuate the space.

A social space at the British Deputy High Commission, The Botanical Club has joined hands with the Madras Art Weekend to bring art to the forefront through The Madras Art Salon, a monthly showcase of emerging and established artists. In its first edition, the Madras Art Salon is hosting a solo showcase of Chennai-based journalist and artist Narayan Lakshman’s works.

“For the next 12 months, we will feature an emerging or established artist and spotlight their work by displaying around 15 artworks. For us, it is a means to reach out to a wider community and get them to appreciate art. The purpose is to build an ecosystem with art enthusiasts, collectors, and others who are interested in art in some way,” says Upasana Asrani, founder, Madras Art Weekend.

Speaking about their tie-up with the British Deputy High Commission and The Botanical Club, Upasana adds that they are particularly keen on pushing the narratives of artists largely from the South.

For Narayan, working on 13 works within a month for this showcase, meant a unique challenge: one that made him apply his mind to questions of discipline,



Stirring from the still

In its first edition, The Madras Art Salon spotlights the 13 works of journalist and artist Narayan Lakshman at The Botanical Club, a social space in the British Deputy High Commission, Chennai



A meditative canvas (Clockwise from far left) Narayan Lakshman; and paintings as a part of the showcase for The Madras Art Salon. JOHAN SATHYADAS

technique, and materials. “From sawdust and wax to sand, and of course my standard acrylics, I have tried to showcase a variety of materials for people to enjoy,” he says.

Narayan further says that this body

of work, created for the Madras Art Salon is focussed on taking forward his own artistic vision, centered on zen.

“Art for me, has always been about that meditative experience, and my hope always is that any viewer of my artwork connects with themselves because the art gives them a moment, or a pause. Art can provoke, it can be angry, an act of protest and can be many things to many people, but mine specifically comes from this place of looking for a zen moment,” he adds.

Much like he describes, Narayan’s art has a gentle, calming stillness to it where colours capture his vision. If greys and whites take centerstage in Cool Peace, where Narayan dabbles in acrylics, sawdust and sand on canvas; flecks of black and gold stand out against red in The Unvarnished Truth, where acrylics and aluminum come together on canvas.

“In the breathless rush of producing these works, I actually made some headway this time with new ways of mixing materials. I realised for instance that if I mix molten wax with water colours, it produces fabulous effects on canvas,” Narayan explains. Mystic Earth, a piece that has acrylic and wax on canvas, presents an almost three-dimensional spectrum of colours, from ochre to umber.

Narayan says that as he largely paints for himself and enjoys being around his art, there are mixed feelings that come with his art leaving the studio. “I am however thrilled to be part of a showcase like this which takes my art to a larger audience. I feel this is necessary for an artist to keep producing more, and innovating,” he says.

The Madras Salon will now be a part of the Madras Art Weekend’s activities around the year, in its quest for art appreciation and bringing together a community of art lovers in the city.

“Inspired by this, I also hope that more venues in the city will open up this way as a platform for artists from the city,” Narayan adds.



From Iran, with hope
Nasrin Karimi at her new
takeaway outlet on
Khader Nawaz Khan Road;
(right) a dish from her
menu. R RAVINDRAN



A lot of youngsters come here. And most of them want protein. So that's what we will give them in the form of sandwiches, pizzas with a generous topping of minced chicken, chicken steak, mutton shank with jewel rice...

NASRIN KARIMI

memories of her family dining together, three meals a day. "We wouldn't start till our mother sat down to eat," she smiles, and adds, "Now I keep a Persian news channel on when im cooking. I, infact, have a separate phone just to listen to Persian news and programmes."

Iran's "peculiar situation" has affected Nasrin. Though she tries to keep her emotions in check when she is working, she says, "I'm also human." "Today, while dispatching orders, I forgot to send one dish. If not for the war I could have done more even in this new space." But despite all odds Nasrin's warmth is intact and so are her comforting hugs.

Shiraz is open from 3pm to 1am. At Gems Court, Khader Nawaz Khan Road. For details, call 9840572126

The soul of Persia in Chennai

Shiraz Art Cafe, Chennai's Iranian restaurant, opens a takeaway outlet on Khader Nawaz Khan Road

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Nasrin Karimi is no stranger to conflict. The affable lady from Iran, left home in Shiraz at 19 and moved to Chennai in 1980, during the Iran-Iraq war. And even though she is nearly 4,000 kilometres from Iran, the impact of the crisis in her homeland follows her like a shadow.

Nasrin gave Chennai its first Iranian restaurant – Shiraz Art Cafe that came up at the Cholamandal Artists Village in 2011 and brought with it flavours from Iran, like tahdig and gheymeh.

This week she launched her new takeaway outlet on Khader Nawaz Khan Road. But unlike the unbridled joy that followed the launch of her first cafe 15 years ago, this one felt muted. "We (Nasrin and her brother

Dariush Karimi) rented out this spot on this prime location four months ago. But in December we lost our youngest brother to the turmoil in Iran. He was 46. So, we were not in a fit state to set up operations," says Nasrin.

The takeaway has a limited menu. It does not feature the usual gormeh sabzi but it does have chello kebab, and koobideh kebabs made of ground meat.

"With KNK Road set to remain open 24/7, a lot of youngsters come here. And most of them want protein. So that's what we will give them in the form of sandwiches, pizzas with a generous topping of minced chicken, chicken steak, mutton shank with jewel rice and desserts like tarhalva halva..."

There is also gilli biryani which is Nasrin's version of the berry pulao she tried at Britannia & Co in Mumbai.

The kebabs and the steak are our favourites from her new menu. It will also feature a special every day. We also enjoy her popular guava slushee which soothes like a cool breeze on a summer day. If you are feeling adventurous try the new orange jigarthanda, tart but refreshing.

The new Shiraz takeout is a small space so Nasrin does not want to get into elaborate cooking. Despite that the dishes are flavourful. She also sources some of her ingredients like saffron, sumac, lemon, and rose water from Iran. "But with the current situation even if I run out of stock, I can use Indian saffron and ingredients," she says.

Nasrin has also started a new bed and breakfast facility in Uthandi that they rent out to groups of 10-15 guests. It is a large four bedroom villa that overlooks a crystal blue pool and is surrounded by greenery, clusters of bougainvillea and bright flowers, with lillies and a variety of floral arrangement on almost every table and corner of the house. In some way, this is inspired from Shiraz, a city known for poetry and flowers. "All houses have a water body in the yard and there are rose

plants; during spring the mountains have lillies...its very beautiful," she says.

Naturally, she misses home. But her brother Dariush keeps her company although they still argue like kids. Dariush jokes that Nasrin has hidden his passport so he

doesn't leave. It is cooking that primarily keeps Nasrin connected to her roots. When she misses her people too much she makes gormeh sabzi, a dish her mother used to make well, and a vegetarian, fenugreek and onion rich soup called eshkeneh. It brings back

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Movement, music and shared stories

Chennai will host a cross-cultural performance this weekend as GUURANDA x KMMC, an Australia-India collaboration, makes its premiere in the city. Conceived by Jacob Boehme, the work brings together Narungga Elders and artists with Indian dancers, choir members and puppeteers in a shared artistic experience. Presented in India by Shreya Nagarajan Singh Arts Development Consultancy in collaboration with KM Music Conservatory, the performance explores a cultural exchange through movement, music and storytelling. The production reflects a coming together of diverse traditions, offering audiences an immersive and collaborative public performance. @Tower Park, Anna Nagar. March 21 and 22. 6pm to 8pm. Entry is free and open to the public.

Diaspora diaries

Chennai is in for an evening of candid humour as Canada-based Tamil comedians, Mithusha (Me2Chat) and Sunthar V are all set to perform in the city. With two back-to-back shows planned, the event offers comedy lovers a chance to experience an intimate, live setting where spontaneity and audience connection take centrestage. Sunthar V seamlessly blends sharp storytelling with cultural wit. He is known for his ability to navigate identity, queerness, and the absurdities of modern life with humor and heart. Mithusha (Me2chat) is known for relatable humor rooted in South Asian identity and diaspora life. @Punch Comedy Club, Alwarpet. March 21, 6pm and 8pm. Tickets at outworld.fanpit.live starting ₹1,000.

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New horizon Rajisha Vijayan; (below) in a still from *Masthishka Maranam*. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

bring in anything she had done before, which, to both Krishand's and her credit, she did not. "It was about channelling who Frida was, while ensuring that nobody figures her out. There is an ambiguity to her character that I felt should lead to empathy for her, but not criminalise her although we know what she has done."

She knew that the film would require an over-the-top performance for everybody, especially for her. Speaking of the prep she says, "Mental preparation went into it, but there was also the physicality of it," says Rajisha. More than for weight loss, she trained physically for six months to gain strength, along with a month of boxing.

Despite the preparations, workshops, and rehearsals, she was worried about getting it right. Her mind was put at ease only after the release.

Over the past year, Rajisha has been part of films that have garnered attention like the Tamil film *Bison Kalamaadan*, *Kalamkaval* and now, *Masthishka Maranam*. Is it her being selective about her projects? "Lately, the characters written for female actors are not strong enough. There are fewer of those now. There is no dearth of talented female actors in our industry. The female characters should be organic to the story, and of late, because of the times we live in – with nuclear families, the mothers, sisters or mother-in-law characters are not part of the narrative. Romance in the movies is also not how it was," she says.

She is currently filming Amal Neerad's *Bachelor Party Deux*, and the Tamil film *Sardar 2* is ready; she is also looking at other industries like the Telugu and Hindi film industries. "I have never differentiated between industries or mediums, whether it is theatre, feature or a short film. I am very happy acting."

Becoming Frida

Rajisha Vijayan talks about how she transformed to become Frida Soman in the sci-fi satire *Masthishka Maranam*, directed by Krishand

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The courtroom scene in Krishand's based-in-the-future flick *Masthishka Maranam* - A Frankenbiting of Simon's *Memories*, where Frida Soman unleashes a monologue on how women celebrities are perceived/consumed, questioning the public's appetite for morsels of their lives, is especially thought-provoking. It was also one of those scenes from the film, which made Rajisha Vijayan, Frida in the film, wonder if the audience would think it was too much. "But you need to trust your director and move forward," says

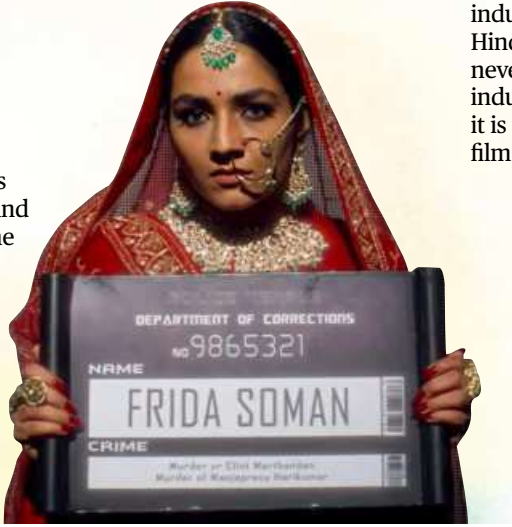
Rajisha over the phone.

She says she was "flabbergasted" by the idea when she heard the story. "I was not worried about how we would execute the idea. I felt this was something we should do."

Masthishka Maranam delves into the probable shape of technology in the future. In this future, memories are on sale, and some even become games in the VR universe. The film is a conversation that was needed, she maintains. "Many actors [women] are speaking about it now, but we have been thinking about it. A lot of them told me at the film's premiere that they felt seen. Somebody has articulated

things that they had been wanting to say. When it happens or is shown in a film, it gives people a voice to use later on. I am not implying that they are saying it now because of our film, but it has given voice to things we have felt. Technology is changing, everyone has a phone and a camera ready to click photographs in whatever angle they please. Some of these cameras can zoom in 26 times! What can we do?" she says. Disturbing iterations of these thoughts feature in *Masthishka Maranam*.

Rajisha has been applauded for her over-the-top turn as the high-strung Frida. Krishand had several references for the character, but Rajisha had none. He watched her previous work to ensure that, as Frida, she did not



Ambition, love, and greed

Rajkumar Rao and Keerthy Suresh will be seen next in *Raftaar*, Amazon MGM Studios has announced. Directed by Aditya Nimbalkar, the film has been produced by Patralekhaa and will be released in theatres on July 24, 2026. The makers unveiled a logo of the film to make the announcement. As per a press release, the film is set in a "highly competitive business of education" and is "a gripping drama of ambition, love, and greed". "At its heart lies a fast-rising start-up and a charged relationship between a driven man and an equally ambitious woman. As money, power, and greed spiral, their hunger to win begins to clash with love. The rise is intoxicating, but after the fall, the question is simple: can they fight their way back to the top, or is this where it all ends?", read the synopsis shared by the makers. Written by Rohan Narula, *Raftaar* also stars Anurag Thakur, Rohan Verma, Tanya Maniktala, and Rajat Kapoor in pivotal roles.

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Want to Lose Weight... But Pain Won't Let You Move?

Doctors often say, "Walk more. Exercise."

But when knee pain or back pain makes every step hurt, movement becomes the problem.

Painkillers aren't a long-term answer. And surgery isn't for everyone.

That's why pain management focuses on reducing pain first, so you can move safely again.

At Epione Pain Management Centre, Egmore our specialists offer:

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